rightsizing the armed forces and recruit only the numbers needed rather than creating a cadre of terminated Agniveers by tinkering with the established recruiting system.

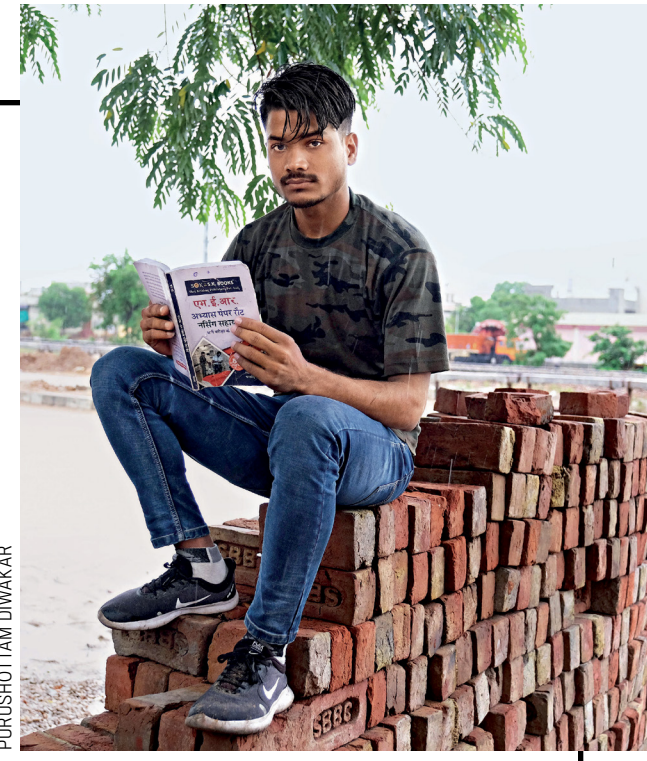
WHY THE ANGST OVER AGNIVEERS?

If Agnipath's goal is to make the armed forces young, fighting fit and adaptable, why is there so much resistance and anger towards the scheme? The real reason is, that barring defence circles, thousands of aspirants seemed unaware of the changes and it dropped like a bombshell on them. The Modi government, after all, does have a penchant for ramming through reform without communicating effectively with all stakeholders.

The Agnipath plan was kept under wraps despite several members of Parliament frequently seeking answers on recruitment in the forces. For example, on December 13, 2021, in response to questions in the Rajya Sabha, Ajay Bhatt, the minister of state for defence, revealed in a written answer that 122,555 posts were lying vacant in the three armed forces. The bulk of them were in the army, which had 104,653 vacant posts, constituting 8.7 per cent of its total strength of 1,189,368. The minister also assured the House, "It is the endeavour of our government to fill up the vacancies in the armed forces in a systematic and time-bound manner, which is a continuous process." Then, in March, to another a question by a member, defence minister Rajnath Singh gave a list of those who had been enrolled for recruitment in 2018-19 and 2019-20, averaging 80,020 in two years. He did admit, though, that since Covid broke out in March 2020, they had suspended the recruitment process for the army. He then went on to reiterate that "sufficient recruitment is being undertaken to meet manpower requirements of the Indian armed forces".

It seemed like business as usual till the defence minister and three chiefs held a press meet on June 14 to announce the Agnipath scheme. Days later, DMA's Puri would emphatically state that the services had held over 150 meetings spanning 500 hours to discuss Agnipath, the defence ministry had held an additional 60 meetings of over 150 hours and then the whole of government (including the prime minister's office) held 44 meetings that took up 100 hours. That comes to 750 hours, or 31 days, of non-stop work 24x7.

Others in the know say that though the process had been on for two years, it lay dormant and that only in May did the PMO ask for work to be speeded up. Initially, the programme was to be called the 'Tour of Duty' model of volunteer conscription, with 50 per cent of the recruits being retained and 50 per cent exiting after a four-year period but later they settled for 25 per cent. The prime minister apparently was keen that Agnipath take off because, as an official put it, "He saw it as an opportunity for nation-building through empowered, disciplined and skilled youth with military ethos in civil society. By imparting them specialised skills, the Agniveers will be a talent pool both the government and the private sector can tap."



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

CASE STUDY | RAJASTHAN

AMIT KUMAR, *20*

BA, with biosciences in senior secondary
Kaman, Bharatpur

"Was the physical exam a hoax?"

Amit had cleared his physical and medical tests last year, after preparing for years. He shifted to Jaipur last July to enrol in coaching classes for the written exam. His monthly expense here is Rs 12,000, for which his labourer father has taken a loan. He is the third of four sons, his elder two brothers being unemployed. He believes that if the PM and defence minister have announced the scheme, "it must be correct and in the national interest". But he does hope that the results of his physical and medical tests are considered, especially after he heard the army chief say that since the medical tests were conducted several months ago, the authorities weren't sure how fit the aspirants were. Amit says he feels cheated since he ran with 200 people for the physical test in defiance of Covid protocol. Yet the written test was endlessly postponed, citing Covid restrictions.

–Rohit Parihar